



When you smell bad

Nivea Men has developed a smartphone app, NOSE, to sense when you smell bad.
<http://dgit.in/youstink>



NKorea's Netflix

The North Korean govt has made a website that will stream on-demand propaganda.
<http://dgit.in/nknetflix>

Origins

From Riverdale to Mountain View

From its inception in 1989 upto September 1993, the World Wide Web was entirely manually indexed by hand. Inventor and scientist Tim Berners Lee maintained a list of servers and hosted the same on the CERN web server, but soon the advent of a large number of websites made this system impossible for continued usage.

Tracing the emergence of web based search engines might divert your attention to a certain comic universe. Created in 1990, the first web search engine, that looked for content instead of users, was named Archie by its creator Alan Emtage from McGill University in Montreal. It wasn't due to any particular character fondness - he originally wanted to call it 'archives' but since he had to comply with the Unix standard of assigning programs and files short and cryptic names like cat, grep etc he shortened it to Archie. The primary method of file storage and retrieval around that time was via File Transfer Protocol that involved setting up FTP clients and servers. Even with the arrival of anonymous FTP sites that allowed file hosting, files were still scattered on multiple servers and could only be located by online word of mouth via forums or mailing lists announcing their availability. This changed with the arrival of Archie.

Using a script based data gatherer to retrieve directory listings from such FTP hosting sites and a regular expression matcher program to corroborate search queries, Archie basically scoured the internet to index any files it came across while giving users access to its database. Pretty soon, in 1993, Veronica (Very Easy Rodent-Oriented Netwide Index to Computer Archives) joined the party. The University of Nevada System Computing Services group created a system pretty similar to Archie, but for Gopher files. Another system called Jughead (Jonzy's Universal Gopher Hierarchy Excavation And Display), a little rougher around the edges, arrived soon seemingly just to complete the trio. Veronica provided

a keyword based search of most Gopher menu titles in the entire Gopher menu listings, whereas Jughead was a tool for obtaining menu information from specific Gopher servers.

Around the same time Oscar Nierstrasz from the University of Geneva created a series of Perl based scripts for the purpose of indexing. His work later formed the foundation for the W3Catalog, world's first primitive search engine released in September 1993. In the same year, in June, MIT based Mathew Gray created the world's first web robot named the World Wide Web Wanderer, whose purpose was to generate 'Wandex', an index. By 1995,



Ted Nelson coined the term hypertext

the Wanderer succeeded in counting the number of websites on the internet.

The title of the world's second search engine goes to Aliweb, which also released in November 1993. This engine did not use automation and instead trusted web administrators to notify the existence of each site on an Index file. Jumpstation, created by Jonathan Fletcher in December 1993, was a search engine that put to use a web robot for indexing and a web form to take the query in. Now that we think about it, the Jumpstation was the first one to comply with the three essential features of a Search engine - crawling, indexing and searching, and it's only limitations were due to the weak hardware it had to run on. The first text search based on a crawler was WebCrawler that emerged in 1994. This one allowed users to search

for words within a webpage. After this, a number of search engines emerged that piqued public interest were like Magellan, Excite, Infoseek, Inktomi, Northern Light, AltaVista and even Yahoo!

The Google we know started off by selling advertising spots in 1998 from a small search engine company called goto.com, suddenly making the Search Engine business highly lucrative. Around the turn of the millennium is when Google's search engine finally started gaining popularity. They greatly improved the quality of their search with their Pagerank algorithm, an iterative algorithm that took into account the quality of a page for optimizing search results. It assigned a Pagerank to a website on the basis of the number of websites linking to it along with their Pagerank. This is based on the logic that websites with good content are linked to by outside sources more often than those with bad quality content.

Searching for the future

Pagerank has since evolved to take into account much more complicated factors. Talking about the direction where their Search operation is headed, then Google CEO Eric Schmidt said in 2007 that they want the Search to be more conversational and contextual - like "What should I eat today" etc. In its August 2009 rollout of Caffeine, a Search Architecture, Google brought about changes like heavier keyword weighing and domain age. They once again switched to Hummingbird, another new update that not only improved performance but also the kind of searches that take place nowadays, making it more conversational. And that's merely one platform we are talking about.

Searching by voice and searching by gesture are almost here, especially if you take into account the increasing types of devices coming online. Also, all of this data is often used by Google to show that a search company is also one of the most reliable sources for analytics and trend predictions. 